"A list of 139 people was drawn up and some got Rs 70,000 as compensation and a little less than half a cottah (1 cottah=720 sq ft) of land. But nobody knows who got them. Certainly not the victims," says Hossain.

He also alleges that voters were told Rs 26 crore had been sanctioned for reinforcing embankments, and that those who lost land would be given alternative plots with *patta*s, but nothing came of those promises. The municipality has a budget of Rs 3.5 crore for dropping sandbags along the banks. However, as Halder points out, sandbags and boulders offer only temporary respite against a river determined to let nothing come in the way of its fury. "They always do it just before the monsoon and in a piecemeal way," says Basudev Mondal of Lalutola, who lost five cottahs of land and now earns a daily wage of Rs 200 while his wife Shabita makes Rs 400 a week by rolling 1,000 *bidi*s. With a cottah of land costing Rs 80,000-1 lakh in these parts, Shabita says they have to keep hopping from one place to another until the government gives them alternative land.

In Malda, some 200 displaced families had holed up in Chamagram High School during the Covid lockdown in 2021. Last November, power was cut off to evict them ahead of the school reopening, and the families shifted to the low-lying Gherotala Math, just 600 metres from the river bank. Identified as a red alert zone in the FBA map, it gets inundated even with moderate rainfall. The displaced families have been allowed to stay here until the government arranges alternative land, but have received nothing in compensation or basic infrastructure. "All we have is a plastic sheet over our heads, 4-5 families share each tent. There's no electricity, no toilets," says Jyotsna Mondal, a resident of the camp.

The CPI(M) students' wing organised a community kitchen for a couple of months. Biswanath Ghosh, a veteran party leader in Malda, says the displaced families gheraoed the Block Development Officer's office last October and blocked the national highway a month earlier. But, he says, "the government is yet to act. Labelled as Left supporters, the victims are denied rehabilitation and compensation."

## WHO IS TO BLAME?

The West Bengal government blames the Centre for washing its hands of the maintenance of 120 km of embankments (40 km upstream and 80 km downstream) that was to be under the FBA's jurisdiction as per a water resources ministry decision in 2005. In 2017, the NDA government reduced this jurisdiction to 12.5 km upstream and 6.9 km downstream.

As the erosion since September 2021 occurred along 7 km upstream of the barrage, Bengal's junior minister for irrigation and waterways Sabina Yeasmin accuses the Centre of not doing its job properly. "We apprised the Centre about the erosion, but the repair work by the FBA is substandard and cosmetic," she says.

Countering her charge, BJP MLA Srirupa Mitra Chaudhury says, "Ganga is designated as National Waterways I and, as per regulation, its dredging can happen only in areas that are 50 metres wide and three metres deep. The river doesn't maintain such criteria in large parts except during the rainy season, thwarting dredging work. The Inland Waterways Authority has undertaken a Rs 150 crore dredging project, but it cannot be implemented in these parts."

Meanwhile, Mamata has dodged questions of her government's responsibility in rehabilitating erosion victims by suggesting that the Centre's Namami Gange programme address the issue. In her letter to the PM, she demanded restoration of the FBA's pre-2017 jurisdiction. Saying that her government had to spend Rs 250 crore for urgent repair work at 31 new vulnerable spots, she also asked for Rs 571 crore assistance for a 37 km stretch that requires immediate attention.

Chaudhury, however, argues that although the river is under the Union waterways ministry's jurisdiction, its banks are the responsibility of the state. "The state has to cooperate with the Centre for comprehensive planning and execution, which never happens," she says. In the state government's defence, a secretary for irrigation and waterways, who does not wish to be named, says, "We have submitted some embankment protection projects like boulder pitching and sand-bag dropping a year ago to the Ganga Flood Control Commission, but are yet to get a go-ahead. They had queries, we answered them and you know how things go back and forth. There's no 100 per cent solution as the soil in these areas is soft alluvial and no amount of fortification can bind it." Meanwhile, Prof. Hazra suggests that the government demand a fair share from the National Disaster Management Authority's funds or seek World Bank aid to address the problem of large-scale displacement. It may be the only recourse for a people stuck in purgatory. ■

**The state accuses the Centre of not doing its job properly; they, in turn, say only the river is in the Union waterways ministry's jurisdiction, its banks are the state's responsibility**